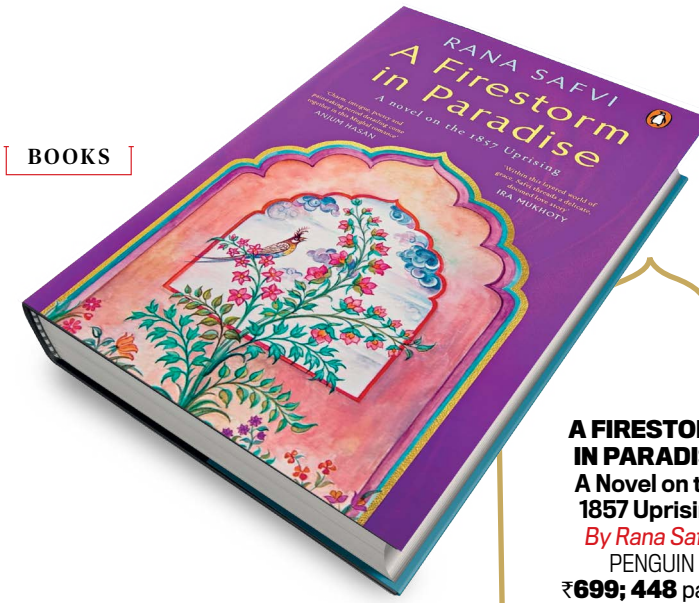
such an established democracy, developed institutions, and a system of checks and balances, not do better in its ending of Empire?"

That the book is written for a British audience is apparent in both the language—a great-grandmother's "white dupatta scarf"—and references—"Babur, a near contemporary of Henry VIII". And yet, the rare mix of research and storytelling makes this a great read for anyone who wants to understand the history of South Asia's present. The political divides of the 1930s and '40s emerge more intimately than in most academic histories: Nehru and Jinnah being disturbed by Gandhi's use of religious symbolism, or Mohammad Ali Jauhar, of Khilafat Movement fame, saying, "Nationalism divides, but faith binds."

It is disturbing to see the present-day resonances, Husain agrees, "in how much of what drove decision-making in 1947—or has happened since—remains, whether it's the insecurity minority communities can experience, or the role of the military in governance." But I felt also a great distance from the past, in ordinary people's identification with something greater than the self. When Shahid is en route to England for military training, his cousin Shaukat writes to him: "Remember that this poor, disorganised, half-fed country is your native land.... Bring back to its shores the accumulated experience of other people." I do not know if many ordinary South Asians today feel such idealism. ■

–Trisha Gupta



A FIRESTORM IN PARADISE
A Novel on the 1857 Uprising
By Rana Safvi
PENGUIN
₹699; 448 pages

Love in a Time of War

***Rana Safvi**, one of India's foremost narrative historians, has written her debut novel*

As followers of historian Rana Safvi's writing, be it her books or her blog on India's syncretic Ganga-Jamuni *tehzeeb*, we were eager to get our hands on her first work of fiction–*A Firestorm in Paradise: A Novel on the 1857 Uprising*.

Beautiful artwork by Shubham Singh on a cover designed by Shadab Khan usher the reader into a world that prized the finer facets of life. The story unfolds through the character of Falak Ara, daughter of a concubine from the zenana of emperor Bahadur Shah Zafar. A chance encounter with a prince leads to love and longing, sighs and quivers. But what is ostensibly a love story set in the 1850s is also made more potent with palace intrigue, myriad mysteries, and an atmosphere rife for dissent under the British yoke.

Safvi, who has penned several impeccably researched books on the capital city of yore, brings her immense knowledge of the many cities of Delhi, her fascination with the poets whose words have cast a glow on its roads and ramparts, and the intricacy of the customs that Dilliwalas down the ages observed.

She's extremely conversant with the conversations amid the various classes of Shahjahanabad, being able to shift gear easily between the flowery speech of royalty and nobles and the colourful expletives of the common folk who attend to them. And for the minutiae of daily life, from the embroidery on the outfits to the delicacies served at dinner, from the music that moved souls to the architecture, few could do a better job than Safvi. In this novel, as in all her previous books, it's the city of Delhi that exudes 'main character energy' more than any other.

While she gets every facet of the place just right, where she falters is in the setting of the right pace. We believe the book's readability would have been greatly enhanced by better editing to weed out irrelevant characters, clunky phrases and several repetitions.

As it happens, a story that has the potential to be incendiary, with the match of love and rebellion sparking, turns out to be a slow burn and almost a damp squib because not enough emphasis is laid on its progression.

Without giving out any spoilers, we can vouch that the promised firestorm does take place in the crumbling paradise that Safvi describes with such perfection, but perhaps all the details fail to fan the flames of desire on the page or ignite the reader's imagination quite as much as we would've liked. ■

RANA SAFVI'S Shahjahanabad is exquisitely detailed, but her narrative suffers from not having the right pace

–Priya Pathiyan